

Effective Assessment Practices

Plain words. Everyday classrooms. Real Ghanaian schools.

A practical workshop for Senior High School teachers — every technical term explained in plain English, with a classroom picture you already know.

KATON 2026

Based on the Teacher Assessment Manual and Toolkit — NaCCA, Ministry of Education, Republic of Ghana

Workshop Agenda

Two hours thirty minutes · with a break

00:00	Welcome & Workshop Objectives	5 min
00:05	Icebreaker — One Word for Assessment	5 min
00:10	Session 1: Understanding Assessment — Purpose & Types	20 min
00:30	Session 2: Ghana's Assessment Policy Landscape	15 min
00:45	Break	15 min
01:00	Session 3: Principles of Effective Assessment	15 min
01:15	Session 4: Assessment Strategies Across Levels	20 min
01:35	Practical Workshop: Design a Task & Rubric	25 min
02:00	Gallery Walk & Group Share-Outs	10 min
02:10	Using Assessment Data: Feedback & Records	10 min
02:20	Common Challenges & Practical Solutions	5 min
02:25	Action Planning & Closing	5 min

By the End of This Workshop, You Will Be Able To...

Four things. That is the whole promise.

1

Distinguish & Apply

Distinguish formative and summative assessment, and use each purposefully at the right point in a lesson or term.

2

Navigate Policy

Explain Ghana's continuous assessment requirements, and locate your grade level within the Standards-Based Curriculum.

3

Design Fair Tools

Create valid, fair and inclusive assessment tasks and simple rubrics suited to your learners' level.

4

Use Data for Learning

Turn assessment results into targeted feedback, better teaching decisions, and clear records.

Note the verb in objective 3: “design”, not “discuss”. By 1:35 this afternoon you will have built something — not just talked about it.

Icebreaker — One Word for Assessment

Five minutes · honesty welcome, formality not required



5 MINUTES

Think

When you hear the word “assessment”, what is the FIRST word that comes into your mind? Not the textbook word. Your honest word.

Share

Turn to the person beside you. One word each. Thirty seconds. No explaining, no defending — just the word.

Collect

We will hear a few out loud. Every word is welcome — including the uncomfortable ones.

WHY WE START HERE

You will hear words like stress, marks, fear, pressure, paperwork, ranking. You may also hear growth, feedback, help, understanding. Both sets are honest — and the difference between them is the whole point of today.

SESSION 1

20 MINUTES

Understanding Assessment

Purpose & types — what assessment is for, and the family of tools.



Assessment — The Plain Meaning

The single most important definition of the day

PLAIN ENGLISH

Finding out what a learner knows and can do, and how far they have travelled towards the goal you set. It is gathering information about a learner in order to make a decision about their learning.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

It is not only the end-of-term paper. It is the question you asked in the middle of the lesson and the blank faces that answered it. It is the exercise book you marked at 9pm. It is watching a group argue over a titration and realising they have misunderstood the indicator. Every one of those is assessment — and every one of them changed what you did next.

The official wording says the same thing: “the process of collecting information on the learner to help in deciding the degree to which the learner has achieved the expected learning outcomes/standards.”

Why We Assess — The Purposes

Assessment is not one thing doing one job

To improve learning

The main purpose. Information gathered DURING learning, used to adjust teaching while there is still time to help.

To diagnose

Before teaching, to find out what learners already bring and where the gaps are.

To inform teaching

Your planning for next week should be shaped by what last week's assessment revealed.

To certify and select

At the end, to summarise achievement for transcripts, placement and employers. A legitimate purpose — just not the only one.

To motivate and involve

Assessment that learners understand and act on builds ownership. Assessment that only judges breeds fear — as the icebreaker showed.



Checking what learners already bring, before you build on it.



FORMATIVE ASSESSMENT • ASSESSMENT FOR LEARNING + AS LEARNING

Tasting the Soup

You taste while it is still on the fire. No salt? Add some. Too much pepper? Add water. You have not failed the soup — you have just improved it before anyone sits down to eat. That is assessment FOR learning, and it saves the meal.



SUMMATIVE ASSESSMENT • ASSESSMENT OF LEARNING

Serving the Meal

The cooking is finished. This is the meal as it is. No amount of tasting will help now. You serve it, the family eats, and the meal is judged as served. That is assessment OF learning — end of term, WASSCE, certification.

The Three Sisters: AfL, AaL and AoL

These three acronyms cause the most confusion — here they are side by side

AfL and AaL together make up what the manual calls FORMATIVE assessment. AoL is SUMMATIVE.

Acronym	Full name	Who is doing the work	In one plain sentence
AfL	Assessment for Learning	The TEACHER	I check as we go, so I can teach better.
AaL	Assessment as Learning	The LEARNER	The student checks themselves, so they learn better.
AoL	Assessment of Learning	The SYSTEM / teacher	A final summary of what has been achieved.

A SIMPLE TEST TO USE ON YOUR OWN PRACTICE

Ask: “Who is going to change what they do as a result of this information?” If the answer is the TEACHER, it is AfL. If it is the LEARNER, it is AaL. If nobody changes anything and it just gets recorded, it is AoL.

AaL is the one we most often forget: we tell learners their marks, but we rarely teach them to check themselves — and that is the skill that carries them into university and into work.

Formative vs Summative — Side by Side

The same skills, two different jobs

	FORMATIVE (the tasting)	SUMMATIVE (the serving)
When	During teaching — before, during and after the lesson	After teaching — end of unit, term, year, programme
Purpose	To IMPROVE learning while there is still time	To PROVE and record overall achievement
Who uses it	Teacher and learner	School, WAEC and other external bodies
What it sounds like	“I see where you got stuck — let us try it this way”	“This is your final grade for the term”
Feels like	A conversation, a question, a quick check, a show of hands	A formal paper, a scheduled exam, a transcript
Examples	Questions, exit cards, class exercises, observation, peer assessment, drafts	End-of-term exam, WASSCE, projects, portfolios, practicals

The Golden Rule Most Teachers Miss

The two do not live in separate boxes — they feed each other

PLAIN ENGLISH

Summative results can be used **FORMATIVELY**, and formative work can count **SUMMATIVELY**. The label describes the **PURPOSE** the information is put to — not the test paper itself.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

You mark the end-of-term paper as usual. But instead of only recording the scores, you hand the scripts back, put learners in groups to find the answers to the questions they missed, and you re-teach the two topics the whole class failed. That exam just became a teaching tool. Equally: the class exercises and the group project you grade against a clear rubric — that is the 30% school-based assessment. Your everyday work is already counting towards the final grade.

Why this matters for you: the same piece of work can do two jobs. You are not being asked to double your marking load — you are being asked to use the information twice.

Assessment Is a Cycle, Not an Event

The loop that turns marks into learning — and where it usually breaks



Most schools stop too early

We PLAN, TEACH and ASSESS — then the marks go in the book and nothing changes.

That is record-keeping, not assessment.

The two steps we skip

ANALYSE — look for the pattern, not the person.

ACT — re-teach, regroup, or move on.

The rule on timing

The gap between ASSESS and ACT should be DAYS.

Most of us run PLAN → TEACH → ASSESS and then stop. The learning happens in the last two steps.

Quick Check — Formative or Summative?

Two minutes · call it out · then we discuss

Do not think about the paperwork. Ask: who is going to change what they do as a result of this information?

The situation	Formative or summative?	Why
You give a five-question quiz halfway through a lesson to check understanding.	?	?
You set the end-of-term examination paper.	?	?
You stand beside a group and listen to how they are solving a problem.	?	?
You mark a learner's draft essay and ask them to rewrite one paragraph.	?	?
You submit learners' WASSCE registration grades.	?	?
You grade a group project against a rubric and it counts towards their 30%.	?	?

SESSION 2

15 MINUTES

Ghana's Assessment Policy Landscape

What you are required to do — and who requires it.



Who Does What — The Policy Actors

Six bodies, one system. Knowing who is who makes circulars make sense.

NaCCA

National Council for Curriculum and Assessment. Sets the curriculum AND the assessment guidance. This workshop's manual is theirs.

Ministry of Education

Sets national policy and funds the system. Owns the reforms behind the new curriculum.

Ghana Education Service

Runs public pre-tertiary schools. Your direct employer; issues day-to-day directives.

WAEC

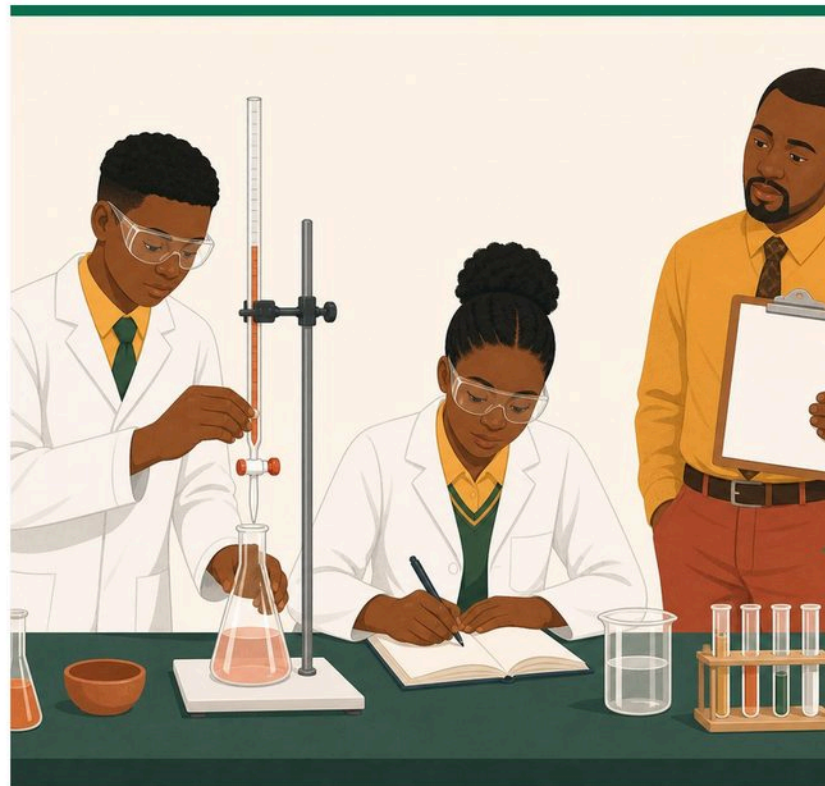
West African Examinations Council. Runs WASSCE — the external 70%. Also advises on item quality.

NaSIA

National School Inspectorate Authority. Inspects schools — and will look at your assessment records.

National Teaching Council

Regulates the teaching profession: licensure, professional standards and continuous professional development.



Different bodies, different jobs — all pointing at your classroom.

The Two Frameworks — NPLAF and SEAF

Where the rules in the manual actually come from

Three acronyms that govern everything you do. You do not need to memorise them — you need to know which one answers your question.

Framework	Full name	What it covers	Why you should care
NPLAF	National Pre-tertiary Learning and Assessment Framework	The national master document. Defines the principles and forms of assessment for ALL pre-tertiary levels.	The root source. Every principle in Session 3 traces back here.
SEAF	Secondary Education Assessment Framework	How SHS / SHTS / STEM learners are assessed within and across grade levels.	The direct rulebook for your classroom. It proposes the two forms: formative and summative.
SBC	Standards-Based Curriculum	The current SHS curriculum. Organised by strands and sub-strands with learning outcomes expressed as standards.	Your teaching and assessment must be aligned to its learning outcomes — that is what validity means in practice.

The 70 / 30 Split — Your Marks Now Have Weight

Why school-based assessment is no longer soft data

The split

Thirty per cent of a learner's final grade comes from work done in YOUR school and marked by YOU. Seventy per cent comes from WAEC's final WASSCE.

What makes up the 30%

Formative work (portfolios, performance and project work) plus summative internal work (end-of-term examinations), recorded in a school-based transcript.

What changed

Internal marks are no longer treated as a formality at the back of the mark book. The 30% now sits on a school-based transcript with far greater transparency and quality assurance.

The consequence

If your school's 30% is not credible, transparent and defensible, the learner is the one who suffers when the transcript is scrutinised and the school is the one that is exposed.

So what?

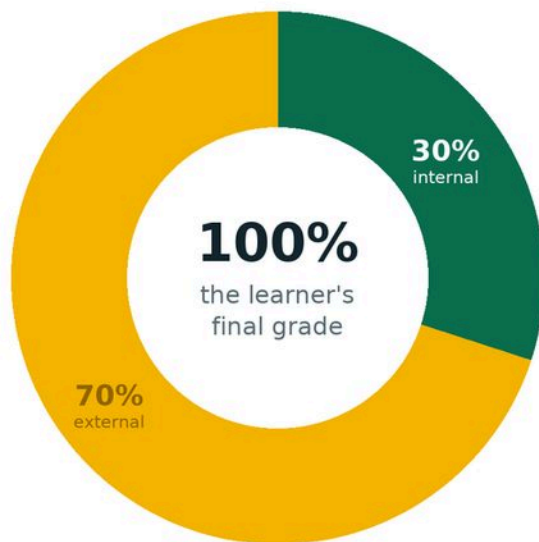
Reliable rubrics applied consistently are no longer just good practice. They are protection for your learners and for your school.



Your 30% is now on the transcript, and it has to be defensible.

The 70 / 30 Split — In One Picture

Why your internal marks carry more weight than they used to



30% — MARKED BY YOUR SCHOOL

Portfolios, project and performance work, plus end-of-term examinations.

Recorded on a school-based transcript.

70% — SET AND MARKED BY WAEC

The final WASSCE paper. Every learner in the country sits it on the same day.

WHY THIS CHANGES YOUR MARKING

The 70 is fixed. The 30 is the part you control — and it now follows the learner.

Thirty per cent marked by you, seventy by WAEC — and the 30 is now the part that follows the learner.

Continuous Assessment — What Is Required of You

The practical obligations, in plain terms

Six obligations that come with the 30%. None of them is optional, and all of them are auditable.

Requirement	What it means in practice	Where teachers commonly slip
Assess against curriculum learning outcomes	Your tasks must test the standards in the Standards-Based Curriculum for your level.	Setting questions on content you taught but which is not in the curriculum standards — or missing standards you did not teach.
Use a variety of assessment methods	Not just written tests. Include projects, portfolios, performance, practicals, observation and oral work.	Relying on class tests alone, then finding the 30% is thin and undefensible.
Record results systematically	Every learner's results kept accurately across the term, with the evidence behind them.	Losing the record book, or reconstructing marks at the end of term. This is the most common quality-assurance failure.
Give feedback learners can act on	Results must feed back into teaching and into the learner's next steps — not just a mark.	Marking and recording without ever handing work back or re-teaching the gaps.
Accommodate learners with SEN	Extra time, alternative formats and appropriate accommodations, applied fairly.	Treating accommodations as favours rather than requirements — and having no record of what was provided.
Be transparent and consistent	Learners know the criteria in advance; the same rubric is used across classes.	Two teachers marking the same subject to different standards, which undermines the whole transcript.

The School-Based Transcript — Why Records Matter

The document that turns your mark book into a learner's future

PLAIN ENGLISH

The school-based transcript records the internal 30% formally, with far greater transparency and quality assurance than the old system. It accompanies the learner beyond your school — to further study, to placements, to employers.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Imagine two learners with identical WASSCE grades. One school's 30% rests on rubrics, marked work and a clean record book. The other's rests on marks entered the week before submission with no evidence behind them. If both transcripts are scrutinised, only one survives. The learner does not lose a place because they knew less — they lose it because somebody's record-keeping was loose. Your record book is not admin. It is a young person's evidence.

The test to apply to yourself: if an inspector asked you to justify one learner's 30% mark today, could you show the work, the rubric and the date? If not, the record needs attention.

What the Transcript Actually Looks Like

A worked example — and the question an inspector will ask about it

SCHOOL-BASED TRANSCRIPT — a worked example

SUBJECT	INTERNAL (30)	WASSCE (70)	FINAL (100)	GRADE
Core Mathematics	24	52	76	B2
English Language	25	48	73	B3
Integrated Science	20	41	61	C4
Social Studies	22	45	67	C5
Elective Mathematics	26	55	81	A1

The internal 30 is built from portfolio + project/practical + end-of-term exam.

The question an inspector will ask: “Show me the work behind this 24.”

Every number in the internal columns must be traceable to a piece of marked work.

Break

15 minutes · back at 01:00

When we return: the seven principles that hold up every good assessment — and then you will design your own task and rubric.

SESSION 3

15 MINUTES

Principles of Effective Assessment

Seven pillars. Remove one, and the roof leans.



Seven Pillars — Hold Up the Roof

Everything that follows rests on these



Seven pillars. Remove one, and the roof leans.

1 • Validity

Am I measuring the RIGHT thing?

2 • Reliability

Do I get the SAME result every time, whoever marks it?

3 • Fairness and ethics

Does every learner get an EQUITABLE chance?

4 • Transparency

Do learners know WHAT they are judged on and HOW?

5 • Inclusivity

Is it accessible to ALL learners, without exception?

6 • Practicability

Can I ACTUALLY do this with my time and my class size?

7 • Assessment utility

Is it USEFUL — does anybody learn anything from it?

1 • Validity — Measuring the Right Thing

The pillar most often broken without anyone noticing

PLAIN ENGLISH

Are you actually measuring the thing you say you are measuring? A valid assessment measures the important learning outcomes of the curriculum — not just whatever was easiest to set.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

A trader uses a weighing scale to sell yam. If she used that scale to measure the LENGTH of the yam, the reading would be worthless — not because the scale is broken, but because it is measuring the wrong thing. Now think of your last class test. Your learning outcome said learners should ANALYSE data. But every question you set asked them to RECALL a definition. Your test was neat. It was well marked. It was simply measuring the wrong thing. That is an invalid assessment — and the learners who studied hard still lost marks for it.

The teacher's quick validity check: "Does this question actually test the skill I said I was teaching?" If the answer is no, the marks it produces mean very little.

2 · Reliability — The Same Result Every Time

Reliability is about trust in the numbers

Plain English

Do you get the same result every time, whoever is doing the marking? Reliable results are dependable enough to make decisions with.

The classroom picture

A market scale that gives the same weight for the same pile of tomatoes — on Monday or Saturday, whoever is standing at the stall. Now imagine the scale was generous on Monday and harsh on Saturday. Nobody would trust that market again.

Where we break it

If this term's 30 marks in your subject are generously given and next term's are harsh, learners are being ranked against a ruler that keeps changing length. With the 30% now on a transcript, that is no longer just unfair — it is indefensible.

How the manual says to fix it

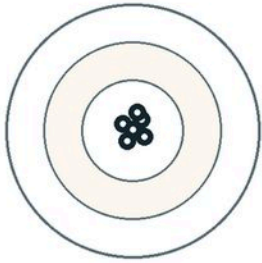
Clear learning outcomes · a colleague reviews your marking · more than one assessment method for the same outcome · proper marking schemes with weightings · rubrics given OUT before the task · a calm, suitable room.



Same pile, same reading — every time.

Validity and Reliability Together

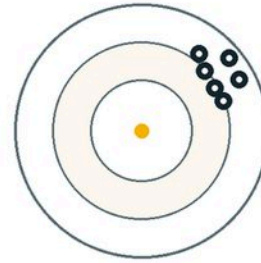
The two pillars side by side — the target explains both in one picture



VALID AND RELIABLE

On the centre, every time.

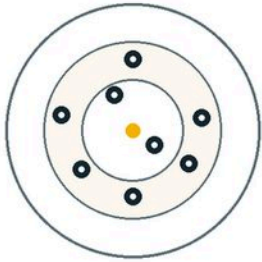
The right thing, measured well.



RELIABLE, NOT VALID

Tidy — and off target.

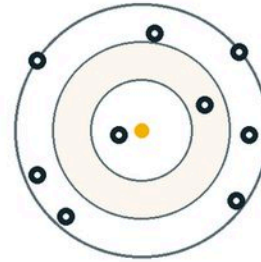
Consistently wrong. Looks competent.



VALID, NOT RELIABLE

Right target, no repeatability.

The average is fine. One mark is not.



NEITHER

Scattered everywhere.

No use for marks, feedback or planning.

Validity is aiming at the right target. Reliability is hitting the same place every time. You need both.

3 · Fairness and Ethics — An Equitable Chance

Fairness is not treating everyone identically — it is giving everyone a real chance

PLAIN ENGLISH

Assessment strategies should give learners an equitable opportunity to demonstrate what they know and can do, taking into account their ability, learning styles, gender and Special Educational Needs. It also means never assessing what you have not taught.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

A test question asks learners to explain the rules of cricket. A learner from a village that has never played cricket — and never seen it — cannot answer, and fails. That question did not measure physics. It measured cricket. Now swap it for a question about the physics of a loaded trotro braking at a junction, and every learner in the room has something to think with. Same physics. Same difficulty. Fair.

The manual's red flags: culturally biased content · unfamiliar words and examples · assessing content you never taught · failing to give SEN learners extra time or alternative formats.

4 · Transparency — No Secret Exams

If learners have to guess what you want, you have already made it harder than it needs to be

PLAIN ENGLISH

Making the assessment process and criteria clear and understandable to learners. They should know what is being judged, how it is judged, and what counts as a pass.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Two teachers set the same project. The first teacher says “do the project, I will mark it” — and the learners spend the week guessing. The second teacher hands out the rubric on day one: what is expected, the marks for each part, what a top answer looks like. Both teachers mark with the same rubric. The second class almost always scores higher — not because they worked harder, but because they knew where to aim. Assessment should not be a guessing game you are the referee of.

Transparency also requires you to: share the learning outcomes being assessed · tell learners the pass mark · share results openly with learners and parents/guardians · give learners a route to seek review and redress if they disagree with a score.

5 · Inclusivity — Fair and Accessible to ALL

Not an extra duty. It is a standing requirement of the framework

PLAIN ENGLISH

Creating assessment practices that are fair and accessible to every learner — regardless of gender, disability, poverty, background or learning difference. The framework names three lenses you must apply: GESI, SEL and SEN.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

A learner with low vision in your class cannot read an ordinary small-print paper — but they understand the work perfectly. A learner who is hard of hearing misses the spoken instructions you gave once, quickly, at the front. A learner who is dyslexic knows the science but loses marks to their handwriting. In all three cases we did not measure their learning. We measured their eyes, their ears and their handwriting. Inclusivity means removing that barrier so the mark reflects the learning.

GESI = Gender Equality and Social Inclusion. **SEL** = Socio-Emotional Learning. **SEN** = Special Educational Needs.

6 · Practicability — Can You Actually Do It?

The pillar that kills the most beautiful assessment plans

PLAIN ENGLISH

The assessment must be feasible, convenient, efficient and successful with the real resources you have — your actual class size, your actual timetable, your actual materials.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

You design a wonderful one-hour one-on-one oral assessment for your Government class. It is rigorous. It is valid. It is inclusive. It is also completely impossible with 60 learners — and by Thursday it will have collapsed into chaos, you will be three weeks behind, and you will abandon it. The plan failed not because it was bad, but because it was not practicable. A good assessment is one you can still run in week eight, when you are tired and the term is crowded.

The three practicability questions: Do I have the materials and the security? · Does this format suit my class size and their level? · Do I have the TIME to set it, mark it, AND give constructive feedback?

7 · Assessment Utility — Is It Actually Useful?

The question that separates data collection from real assessment

PLAIN ENGLISH

The assessment must be useful. It must give you and the learner information worth having, and that information must lead to action.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

You set a class test. You mark it. You enter the scores in the mark book. You file the papers. Term ends. Now ask honestly: did anybody learn anything from that test? If the test did not change what you taught next, and did not change what the learner did next, then all that happened was data collection. Utility is the difference between a test that teaches and a test that merely records.

Utility in practice: state the intended use of the result up front · produce credible information for learners and parents · give constructive feedback · and then ACT on it — re-teach, regroup, intervene, adapt.

SESSION 4

20 MINUTES

Assessment Strategies Across Levels

Choosing the right tool — and matching it to your learners.



Choosing a Strategy — Match the Tool to the Job

The most common mistake is using a test for everything

Start with the outcome, not the tool

Ask first: what should the learner be able to DO? Then choose the method that lets them show it. If the outcome is “dismantle and reassemble”, a written test cannot show it.

Three families of strategy

INFORMAL (questions, observation, exit cards) for quick in-lesson checks. FORMAL WRITTEN (tests, essays, MCQs) for recording. PERFORMANCE (projects, practicals, portfolios, debates) for real application.

Vary your methods deliberately

The manual requires a variety of assessment methods. If all your methods are written tests, you are assessing recall and missing everything else — and your 30% is thin.

Match the level, not the label

The same strategy pitches differently at SHS 1, 2 and 3. Scaffold heavily in Form 1; expect independence by Form 3. We will work through this shortly.

Check the seven pillars before you commit

Will it measure the right thing (validity)? Can you mark it consistently (reliability)? Can you actually run it in week eight (practicability)?

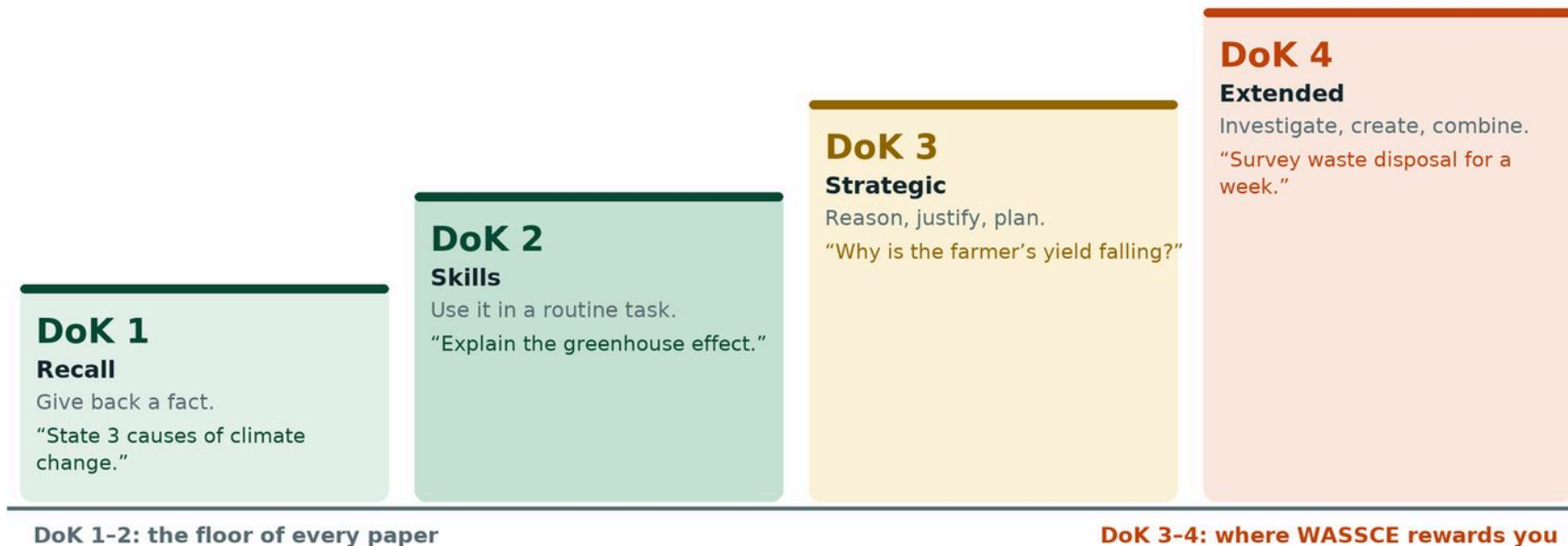


Start with what learners must do, then pick the tool.

Depth of Knowledge — Climbing the Staircase

How DEEP is the thinking? Not how difficult the words look.

DEEPER THINKING — not harder words



The words can stay simple while the thinking goes deep — that is the whole point.

Depth of Knowledge — The Staircase of Thinking

How DEEP is the thinking? Not how difficult the words look.

DoK stands for Depth of Knowledge. It is a ladder, not a difficulty rating — the words can stay simple while the thinking goes deep.

Level	Name	Plain English	SHS example — Social Studies
DoK 1	Recall / Reproduction	Give back a fact you were taught.	"State three causes of climate change."
DoK 2	Skills and Concepts	Use your knowledge in a familiar routine.	"Explain how the greenhouse effect works, using a diagram."
DoK 3	Strategic Thinking	Reason, justify, plan. There is more than one route to the answer.	"A cocoa farmer's yield is falling. Using the data given, diagnose the likely cause and justify your answer."
DoK 4	Extended Thinking	Investigate over time, combine ideas, produce something original.	"Conduct a week-long survey in your community on waste disposal and present recommendations to the school assembly."

Portfolio — The Learner's Own Story

Not a folder of everything. A chosen collection, with reflection.

Plain English

A carefully chosen collection of a learner's work across time, showing progress towards the learning outcomes. Formative as it grows, summative when a rubric is applied at the end.

The classroom picture

Two things separate a real portfolio from a pile of papers. First it is **CURATED** — the learner chooses what goes in, and learns by choosing. Second it carries **REFLECTION** — beside each piece, a short note: “I chose this because...” and “next time I would...”.

Why it is worth the effort

It is the clearest evidence you will ever have of progress over time — and it is pure Assessment as Learning. The learner is judging their own growth, with evidence.

The rule that saves your evenings

You do not mark every piece. You mark the **REFLECTIONS** and the final selection. That is where the thinking is visible.

Where the manual helps

Appendix C.1 gives worked portfolio exemplars for Science and Mathematics, including the rubric. You do not have to invent it.



Curated, with reflection — otherwise it is just a folder.

Debate — Thinking Out Loud

A strategy that assesses reasoning, not just recall



Assessing the reasoning, not the volume.

Plain English

Learners take a position on an issue, argue it with evidence, and respond to the opposing case. You assess the quality of the thinking, not just the conclusion.

The classroom picture

A Government class debates: “Should Ghana raise the minimum wage?” Half the room argues for it, half against. The Economics or English teacher uses the same format for their own content.

What you are actually assessing

Clarity of the argument · use of evidence, not just opinion · quality of rebuttal — do they answer the other side? · listening · respectful disagreement.

The rule that makes it work

Give the rubric BEFORE the debate, and give learners time to research. A debate sprung on them with no preparation assesses confidence, not competence — and it rewards the loudest voices.

Practical and Performance — Doing It For Real

The manual calls it authentic assessment: it looks like real life

Plain English

Learners demonstrate a skill in a real or simulated setting, and you judge the **DOING** — not just the writing about it.

The classroom picture

The Chemistry learner stands at the bench and titrates. The Technical Skills learner dismantles and reassembles an engine. The Visual Arts learner throws a pot. The Music learner performs. You are watching the skill, not reading about it.

What the teacher must do first

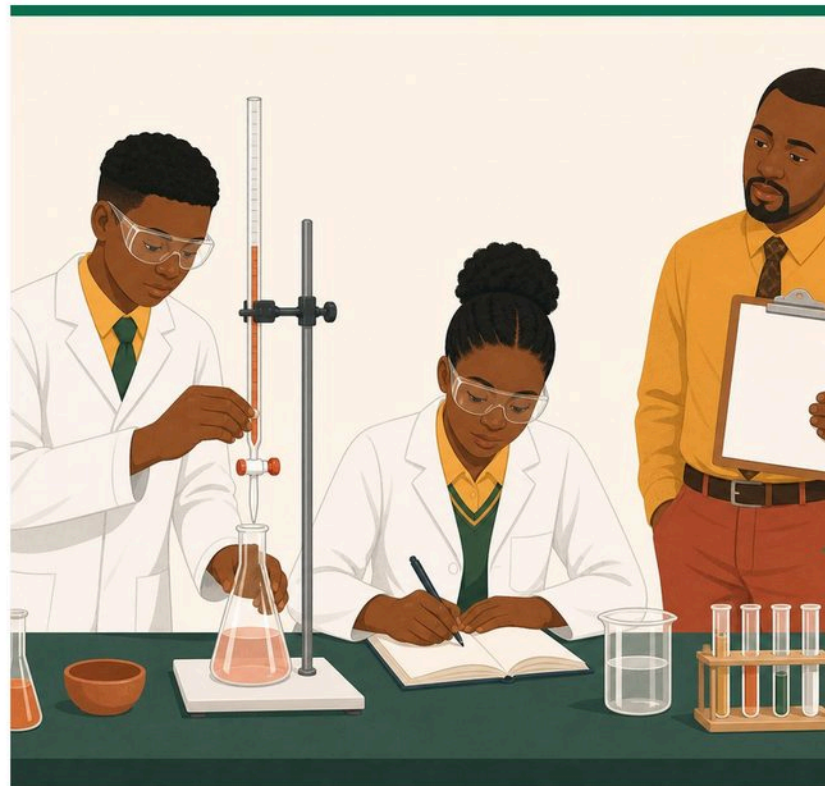
Design a task requiring real application · provide resources, guidance and support · evaluate against **PREDETERMINED** criteria · model the skill · act as coach, not just examiner.

Why the rubric matters most here

In a practical, judgement happens live with no chance to re-read. Without a rubric written in advance you will mark the confident performer higher than the careful one.

No lab? Still possible

The manual explicitly allows real OR simulated contexts. An improvised set-up still counts.



You are judging the doing, not the writing about it.

Rubric — The Recipe Card

The single most useful document in your assessment toolkit



A recipe card with measurements, not guesses.

Plain English

A table showing exactly what counts and how many marks each part is worth, at each level of quality.

The classroom picture

It is a recipe card with measurements. Not “add enough salt” — but “one teaspoon”. Not “write a good essay” — but “three clear arguments, each supported by one example, maximum two pages.”

Why it changes everything

It removes the guesswork for the learner AND the bias from the marker. It is the fastest route to both transparency and reliability at the same time.

The rule nobody follows

Give the rubric OUT BEFORE the task — never after. The manual says this explicitly for performance and practical assessment.

A simple three-band template

EXCELLENT (full marks) · GOOD (most marks) · DEVELOPING (some marks). Three bands is enough to start. Four criteria is plenty.

Matching Strategy to Level

The same strategy, pitched differently at SHS 1, 2 and 3

Same tool, different scaffolding. Pitching Form 1 work at Form 3 level is not rigour — it is a validity failure.

Strategy	SHS 1 (Form 1)	SHS 2 (Form 2)	SHS 3 (Form 3)
Project work	Short, tightly scaffolded, one clear deliverable. Heavy guidance.	Multi-step with milestones. Learner plans more of the process.	Extended and largely independent. Expects synthesis and original thinking.
Debate	Structured roles, given positions, short speaking time.	Learners research their own evidence. Rebuttal expected.	Full format, independent research, higher expectation of rebuttal quality.
Practical / performance	Follow a modelled procedure step by step with close supervision.	Carry out the procedure with less prompting; record results accurately.	Design or adapt a procedure; analyse and evaluate outcomes.
Portfolio	Teacher-guided selection. Simple reflection prompts supplied.	Learner selects with increasing independence. Reflection in more depth.	Self-directed curation with critical reflection on growth.
DoK level to expect	Mainly DoK 1–2, with guided DoK 3.	DoK 2–3 regularly.	DoK 3–4, including extended tasks.

Quick Wins — Three-Minute Tools You Can Use Tomorrow

No budget. No printing. No extra marking load.

Exit card

Last three minutes of the lesson: on a slip, “write one thing you learned today and one thing you are still confused about.” Collect at the door. You now know exactly where to start next lesson.

Entry ticket

First three minutes: one question that shows what they already bring. Free diagnostic assessment, every single day.

Think-Pair-Share

Think alone, then discuss with a partner, then share with the class. Three minutes of real thinking time means the quiet learners at the back have something to say when you ask.

K-W-L chart

Three columns: what I Know, what I Want to know, what I Learned. Makes thinking visible and makes the learner reflective.

Self- and peer-assessment

Learners check their own or each other's work AGAINST THE RUBRIC. Only works if they have the criteria in hand — otherwise it becomes a popularity contest.



Learners assessing each other — with the rubric in hand.

PRACTICAL WORKSHOP

25 MINUTES

Design a Task & Rubric

Something you will actually use — not something you plan to use.



Your Brief — Design a Task & Rubric

25 minutes · in groups of four to six · use a topic you teach this term



25 MINUTES

Work in groups

- 1 Groups of four to six. If possible, group by subject or level so you can help each other. One person keeps time.

Use a REAL topic

- 2 Choose something you will actually teach in the next month. A real topic produces a real tool. An invented one produces a nice-looking document you will never use.

Produce three things

- 3 ONE learning outcome · ONE assessment task · ONE simple rubric. That is all. Not a scheme of work — one task.

Put it on the paper

- 4 Use the A3 sheet. Write large. This goes on the wall for the gallery walk at 2:00, so it must be readable from a distance.

Finish with the checklist

- 5 At minute 20 you will check your work against the six-point quality checklist. Fix the easiest problem, then stop.

Step 1 & 2 — The Outcome and the Strategy

Minutes 0–10 · do these before you think about the task

Ten minutes on these two steps. Skipping them is why assessment tasks fail — the task is always easy once the outcome is clear.

Step	What to decide	The test to apply
1. Write the learning outcome	ONE sentence. “By the end of this, the learner should be able to...” Use an ACTION VERB: explain, calculate, design, evaluate, demonstrate.	Could I show someone else this sentence and would they know exactly what to teach and assess? If not, it is too vague.
1b. Check the DoK level	Is your verb at the right thinking level for your class? State = DoK 1. Explain = DoK 2. Analyse / justify = DoK 3. Design / evaluate = DoK 4.	Does the thinking level match the standard in the curriculum for this level?
2. Choose the assessment strategy	Which family? INFORMAL (observation, questioning) · WRITTEN (test, essay) · PERFORMANCE (project, practical, portfolio, debate).	Could a learner who genuinely has this skill fail this task for a reason that has nothing to do with the skill?
2b. Sanity-check the seven pillars	VALID (measures the outcome) · RELIABLE (markable the same way twice) · PRACTICABLE (runnable in week eight with your class size).	If any of the three fails, change the strategy now — not after you have built the task.

Step 3 & 4 — The Task and the Rubric

Minutes 10-20 · build the task, then the marking criteria

Ten minutes. Keep the rubric simple — three bands and four criteria. A simple rubric used consistently beats a detailed one abandoned in week three.

Step	What to decide	The test to apply
3. Write the task	Exactly what the learner must do. Include the instructions you would give them, and what they must produce. One task — not a list of five.	Could a learner who has the skill show it here? And would a learner who only memorised definitions be unable to fake it?
3b. Consider your SEN learners	What accommodations would this task need? Extra time, larger print, oral alternative, a written alternative to a performance.	Have I decided this in advance — rather than improvising on the day and forgetting to record it?
4. Build the rubric	THREE bands: Excellent / Good / Developing. FOUR criteria at most. Each cell says what the work must show to earn that band.	Could a colleague pick this up and mark the same script the same way I would? That is reliability.
4b. Write the learner-facing version	One or two sentences telling learners what “excellent” looks like. This is the part handed out BEFORE the task.	Have I described the WORK, not the learner? “Clear argument with evidence” — not “very good student”.

Quality Checklist — Before You Finish

Minutes 20–25 · check your own work · fix the easiest problem · stop

Six questions. Five minutes. This is the step that separates a nice-looking document from a usable tool.

Check	Ask yourself	If it fails
Validity	Does my task actually measure the learning outcome I wrote — or has it drifted into something easier to set?	Change the task, not the outcome.
Reliability	Could a colleague mark this the same way I would, using only my rubric?	Add specificity to the vague rubric cells.
Fairness	Does the task assume experiences or contexts some of my learners have not had?	Re-context it to something familiar — the physics of a trotro, not of cricket.
Inclusivity	Who cannot access this task, and what have I put in place for them?	Add an accommodation and write it down.
Transparency	Could I hand this rubric to learners BEFORE the task, and would it help them aim?	Rewrite the language so a learner can understand it.
Practicability	Can I run this in week eight, mark it, AND give feedback — with my real class size?	Scale it down. A smaller task you complete beats a grand one you abandon.

Gallery Walk — Read Each Other's Work

10 minutes · walk, read, leave written feedback



10 MINUTES

Stick your work on the wall

- 1 One sheet per group. Write your subject and level at the top so people know the context.

Walk and read — 6 minutes

- 2 Move around the room reading other groups' work. No talking for the first three minutes — just read. Then you may discuss quietly.

Leave feedback on sticky notes

- 3 One note per sheet. Write ONE thing that would make this task better or fairer. Be specific and kind — “the rubric cell for Good is still vague”, not “needs work”.

Collect your own notes — 2 minutes

- 4 Go back to your own sheet. Read the notes people left for you. You do not have to agree with them all — but read them.

Share-outs — 2 minutes

- 5 We will hear from two or three groups at the front: what did you design, and what did the feedback make you reconsider?

USING ASSESSMENT DATA

10 MINUTES

Feedback & Records

Turning marks into learning — and into records you can defend.



Feedback — The Good Mechanic

Why “good work, 7/10” is not feedback

The useless mechanic

Says “the car is bad” and takes your money. You leave knowing nothing, and the car is no better.

The good mechanic

Opens the bonnet, points at ONE exact part and says: “This hose is cracked. Replace it and the overheating stops.” You now know what to do next.

Plain English

Feedback is information that helps a learner close the gap between where they are and where they need to be.

What it is NOT

It is not a score. It is not praise. “Good work, 7/10” tells a learner nothing about what to do differently. A mark is a verdict; feedback is a map.

The rule teachers break

Feedback without TIME TO ACT ON IT is decoration. If you hand back corrections and immediately move to the next topic, the feedback dies in the exercise book.



Point at the exact part, and say what to do next.

Records — What to Keep, and Why

Because the 30% is now on a transcript that follows the learner

Six things. If you can produce all six for any learner, your 30% is defensible.

What to keep	Why it matters	How to keep it manageable
The assessment task itself	You cannot defend a mark without showing what was asked. Keep a copy of the paper or task sheet, not just the marks.	One folder per class per term. Digital photo of the task sheet if you prefer.
The rubric or marking scheme	This is your evidence that marking was consistent — the reliability pillar made auditable.	Keep the actual rubric, including any changes you made after marking started.
Marks, with a date	Marks without dates cannot show progress over the term, and cannot be audited.	A single clean mark book, updated after each assessment — not reconstructed at the end.
Evidence of a sample of learner work	For any mark that could be questioned, you need at least a sample of the actual work.	Keep the scripts for the assessments that feed the 30%, or a representative sample.
SEN accommodations provided	Required by the framework — and needed to explain a mark later if it is questioned.	A short note in the record against the learner's name: what was provided, and when.
Feedback given	The manual requires that results feed back into learning. Evidence that they did.	A note of the date feedback was returned is usually enough.

From Data to Action — The Whole Point

Assessment that does not change anything was just data collection

Look for the pattern, not the person

Do not just record 45 individual scores. Ask: which questions did the class fail together? Eighteen learners failing the same question is one teaching problem, not eighteen learning problems.

The three responses to a pattern

RE-TEACH the whole class if most failed · REGROUP and target support if a few failed · MOVE ON if everyone passed. Decide deliberately, not by habit.

Close the loop in the next lesson

The gap between the assessment and the response should be days, not weeks. Feedback that arrives three weeks later is history, not feedback.

Use it for your own planning

The manual is explicit: assessment information should modify teaching and learning strategies. Your next week's lesson plan should be visibly shaped by last week's assessment.

Make it visible to learners

Tell them what you noticed and what you are changing. 'I can see we all struggled with this — we will do it a different way today.' That single sentence turns assessment from judgement into teaching.



From mark book to next lesson plan.

Common Challenges & Practical Solutions

The five things you are all thinking about — with honest answers

These are the real constraints — not excuses. Every answer below is something you can start this term without extra budget.

The challenge	What it looks like in school	What actually works
"My class is too large to assess properly."	60 learners, one teacher, no time. Individual oral assessment is impossible.	Do not assess everyone individually. Use methods that scale: whole-class response, exit cards collected at the door, peer assessment with a rubric, group projects with individual accountability. Sample deeply rather than test everyone shallowly.
"There is not enough time in the term."	The syllabus is crowded. Assessment feels like an addition on top of teaching.	Assessment IS teaching, not an addition. Three minutes of exit cards replaces an hour of re-teaching material the class already knew. Start small — one exit card a week, not a full new system.
"Marking already takes my evenings."	Every script marked in full detail, late at night, then filed.	Mark the drafts formatively and the final version summatively. Use rubrics so marking is a judgement against criteria, not a rewrite. And remember: feedback needs time for learners to act on it more than it needs length.
"I was never trained to design rubrics."	Rubrics feel like something other people know how to do.	You do not have to start from a blank page. The NaCCA manual's Appendix C has worked exemplars and rubrics for portfolios, projects, debates, practicals, questioning and more. Adapt one.
"The learners only care about marks."	Learners skip the comments and look at the score.	That is learned behaviour, and it is rational — marks are what they have always been rewarded for. Change it by giving them time to act on feedback and by grading a draft formatively. When feedback visibly improves their next mark, they start reading it.
"What about learners who will not engage?"	Some learners will not speak in a debate, will not participate in peer assessment.	Offer alternative formats rather than excuses. A written alternative to a debate still assesses the reasoning. And check your own task first — often the barrier is the format, not the learner.

Action Planning — One Commitment Each

Five minutes · write it down · say it to the person beside you

Pick ONE thing — not five

Choose the single change you will actually make. Not the ideal system — the realistic next step.

Write it specifically

Weak: “I will use more formative assessment.” Strong: “I will use an exit card at the end of every double period with Form 2 Science, starting Monday.”

Name the first step and the date

What is the very first action? When will it happen? “Print the slips this weekend, use them Monday period 3.”

Say it out loud to your neighbour

Thirty seconds each. Spoken commitment to a peer is much more likely to happen than a private resolution.

Choose from today's toolkit

An exit card · a rubric written BEFORE the task · giving back one end-of-term paper for group correction · a peer-assessment cycle with the rubric · checking your record book is complete.



Not the ideal system. The realistic next step.

Thank You

This morning we wrote one word each for assessment. Most of them were about being judged. Everything we did today was about moving those words — from judgement toward learning.

Taste the soup. Serve the meal. Know which one you are doing, and why.

Your handouts have every term, every principle and every strategy we covered. The NaCCA manual is free online, and Appendix C has ready-made rubrics you can adapt tonight.